Predictive Advantage, Regime Dependence, and Direction-Specific Causal Control in Kinetic Ising Dynamics

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Abstract

We ask whether predictive sufficiency implies causal access in the two-dimensional kinetic Ising model, and whether predictive ranking is stable across dynamical regimes. The answer to both is no. The central result is a predictor-handle dissociation: a coarse macro-state and the fine champion are statistically indistinguishable as predictors of future domain-wall change, yet only the fine structure yields a direction-specific causal handle. A regime-crossover result earns the regime-dependence qualifier and blocks the objection that fine descriptions win simply by having more bits. Four empirical axes support these claims. (**Axis 1, organism comparison**) Fine descriptions based on locally exposed and junction-type defects outperform a block-variance coarse rival for predicting future domain-wall change in the ordered phase; the best organism is $E_{\geq 3} + J$, with predictive advantage $\Delta R^2 = +0.393$ (95% CI [+0.368, +0.421]) against this rival, which achieves $R^2 \approx 0$ for ΔW at this temperature. (**Axis 2, regime crossover**) This advantage reverses sign in the disordered phase (+0.178 ordered, −0.071 disordered), showing that the fine-over-coarse advantage is regime-dependent. (**Axis 3, target specificity**) Under a fine-over-coarse ΔR^2 criterion, future domain-wall change ΔW is the target most specifically favoured by the fine description ($\Delta R^2 = +0.391$); this is not merely the most predictable target in absolute terms. (**Axis 4, causal control**) Biasing the Glauber generator toward wall-reducing flips at exposed sites accelerates future wall removal (aligned arm removes more walls than baseline), while biasing against those flips retards it; this direction-specific sign flip holds across all active perturbation strengths (4/4 sign flips on non-null ε values). (**Dissociation**) The aggregate coarse macro-state $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$ ($R^2 = 0.389$) and the fine champion $E_{\geq 3} + J$ ($R^2 \approx 0.393$) are statistically indistinguishable as predictors of ΔW, yet only the fine structure serves as a causal handle: the generator bias of Axis 4 is conditioned on exposed-site geometry, not on the aggregate $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$. Two descriptions with equivalent predictive power differ entirely in their causal leverage within the same system at the same temperature.

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I. INTRODUCTION

A common working assumption in statistical physics is that different descriptions of the same system may differ in predictive usefulness—but which description is best, and

whether that ranking is stable across regimes and tasks, is not always obvious. This paper studies how predictive and causal usefulness depend on the choice of description in a simple, well-understood dynamical system.

The central question is whether predictive sufficiency implies causal access: can a description that accurately forecasts future domain-wall change be used to controllably change it? We find the answer is no, and that the dissociation is not an artefact of a particular baseline choice: even the strongest available coarse rival $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$ matches the fine champion predictively ($\Delta R^2 = 0.004$, CI includes zero), yet only the fine structure provides a direction-specific causal handle. The crossover result earns the regime-dependence qualifier: the fine-over-coarse predictive advantage reverses sign from ordered (+0.178) to disordered (−0.071 phase), blocking the objection that fine descriptions simply win by having more bits. The fine champion is $E_{\geq 3} + J$; the target most specifically favoured by fine descriptions is ΔW; and the causal sign-flip holds across all 4/4 active perturbation strengths (the $\varepsilon = 0$ null produces a gap consistent with zero, as expected).

a. Why the Ising model. The 2D kinetic Ising model with Glauber dynamics [4, 7] is one of the few systems for which domain-wall coarsening, defect densities, and critical exponents are all precisely characterised [1]. Domain walls provide a structurally meaningful target family: interfaces are the elementary reorganisation objects under coarsening, and their evolution is driven by specific local geometric features of the current configuration. An isolated minority spin surrounded by four unlike neighbours—a site with exposure degree $d_c = 4$—contributes four domain-wall bonds, is energetically costly, and is a natural structural precursor of upcoming interface simplification. This geometry makes the Ising model a clean and interpretable testbed.

b. Why description choice matters. Finer descriptions always contain more bits, but more bits do not automatically produce better predictions for a specific target. The predictive signal for interface-level change lies in sparse, geometrically special objects—exposed tips, junction bends—that coarse block averages discard. In the disordered phase no such sparse structure exists; coarse summaries recover the predictive advantage. And predictive sufficiency does not confer causal access: as we demonstrate, the variable that best forecasts ΔW is not the variable whose structure can be used to controllably change ΔW.

c. Paper organisation. This paper establishes four empirical results and one dissociation result: **(1)** organism comparison in the ordered phase; **(2)** regime crossover demonstrating

regime-dependence; **(3)** target specificity under a fine-over-coarse criterion; **(4)** direction-specific causal control via generator alignment; and **(D)** predictor-handle dissociation. Section II reviews related work. Section III presents the model, observables, and causal protocol. Section IV reports results with figures and tables. Sections V–VI discuss implications and conclude.

II. RELATED BACKGROUND

a. Coarse-graining and renormalisation. The renormalisation group [9, 12] is the canonical framework for relating descriptions at different scales. In that tradition, coarse-graining maps fine configurations to block variables, and RG fixed points characterise universality classes. Our approach is complementary: we ask empirically, for a given target and horizon, which description achieves higher out-of-sample predictive accuracy. Israeli and Goldenfeld [8] showed that cellular automaton coarse-graining can produce exact reduced models, illustrating the system-specificity of which description is "best."

b. Prediction versus causation. The distinction between prediction and intervention is formalised in the do-calculus of Pearl [10] and the interventionist philosophy of Woodward [13]. A variable may be a strong predictor while being causally inert if it is correlated with the true causal driver. We demonstrate this dissociation empirically within Ising: the best predictor of ΔW does not coincide with the structure that can be used to controllably change ΔW.

c. Structural defects in coarsening. The role of domain-wall defects in Ising coarsening is well studied [1, 11]. Isolated minority spins and junction-type sites are energetically unstable and drive local coarsening events. We quantify how well such defects predict future macroscopic wall change and test whether they serve as intervention targets.

d. Macro-micro comparisons in prediction and causation. The causal emergence programme [5, 6] asks whether macro descriptions can have more causal organisation than micro ones, measured by effective information. Our approach differs: we use standard regression criteria for predictive accuracy and direct intervention experiments for causal leverage, without assuming any universal scale ranking.

III. MODEL AND METHODS

A. The 2D kinetic Ising model

We study the ferromagnetic Ising model on a 64×64 square lattice with periodic boundary conditions. Each site i carries spin $\sigma_i \in \{-1, +1\}$. Dynamics are governed by single-spin-flip Glauber updates [4]:

$$p(\sigma_i \to -\sigma_i) = \frac{1}{1 + \exp\big(2\beta h_i \sigma_i\big)}, \tag{1}$$

where $h_i = \sum_{\langle j \rangle} \sigma_j$ and $\beta = 1/T$. A checkerboard update scheme avoids spatial bias. The 2D Ising critical temperature is $T_c \approx 2.269$.

Two anchor temperatures are used: ordered $T = 1.80$ (well inside the ferromagnetic phase) and disordered $T = 2.50$ (above T_c). Each configuration is equilibrated for 1000 sweeps before measurement. Predictive targets are measured at horizon $K = 20$ sweeps.

B. Structural observables

a. Domain-wall count. $W(\sigma) = \sum_{\langle i,j \rangle} \mathbf{1}[\sigma_i \neq \sigma_j]$. Future change: $\Delta W = W(t_0 + K) - W(t_0)$.

b. Exposed-site counts. Exposure degree: $d_c(i) = \sum_{\langle j \rangle} \mathbf{1}[\sigma_j \neq \sigma_i]$.

$$E(\sigma) = \sum_i \mathbf{1}[d_c(i) = 4] \quad \text{(isolated minority spins)}, \tag{2}$$

$$E_{\geq 3}(\sigma) = \sum_i \mathbf{1}[d_c(i) \geq 3] \quad \text{(highly exposed sites)}. \tag{3}$$

c. Junction count. $J(\sigma) = \sum_i \mathbf{1}[d_c(i) = 2 \text{ and non-collinear}]$. Junctions mark the bends and corners of wall segments.

d. Composite organisms. $E_{\geq 3} + J$ is the two-column matrix $[E_{\geq 3}, J]$; each column receives a separate regression coefficient. $E + J$ uses $[E, J]$. These are not scalar sums.

e. Coarse rival.

$$\phi_{\text{var8}}(\sigma) = \frac{1}{n_b} \sum_{b=1}^{n_b} \left(|\bar{\sigma}_b| - \tfrac{1}{n_b} \sum_{b'} |\bar{\sigma}_{b'}| \right)^2, \tag{4}$$

the variance of block-averaged order parameter across 8×8 blocks.

C. Predictive evaluation

Ridge regression, 5-fold cross-validation, $N = 3000$ configurations. Primary statistic:

$$\Delta R^2 = R^2(\text{fine organism}) - R^2(\phi_{\text{var8}}). \tag{5}$$

Confidence intervals use pairwise bootstrap resampling ($B = 1000$) with the same configuration set for fine and coarse predictions.

a. Reproducibility. Stochastic dynamics are implemented via Numba-compiled functions; the Numba random-number generator is seeded independently from the worker-level seed to ensure cross-run reproducibility. Reported confidence intervals are stable to this level of control.

D. Causal protocol: aligned and misaligned generator bias

Rather than forcing state changes at t_0, we modify the Glauber transition probability throughout the K-step evolution. At each exposed site i ($d_c(i) = 4$), the local wall-change contribution of flipping σ_i is

$$\delta W_i = \sum_{\langle j \rangle} \big[\mathbf{1}[\sigma_j \neq -\sigma_i] - \mathbf{1}[\sigma_j \neq \sigma_i]\big]. \tag{6}$$

For a fully exposed site, $\delta W_i < 0$.

Two arms are defined:

Aligned:: $\delta W_i < 0$ transitions promoted ($p \to p + \varepsilon$); $\delta W_i > 0$ suppressed ($p \to p - \varepsilon$).

Misaligned:: Opposite: $\delta W_i < 0$ suppressed, $\delta W_i > 0$ promoted.

Both share initial configuration $\sigma(t_0)$ and are compared to an unperturbed baseline arm. The intervention identifies currently exposed sites ($d_c = 4$) at each of the K sweeps, not from a mask fixed at t_0; this ensures the structural targeting tracks the evolving configuration throughout the K-step evolution. Primary output:

$$\text{gap} = \Delta W_{\text{baseline}} - \Delta W_{\text{arm}}, \tag{7}$$

positive meaning the arm achieves greater wall reduction than baseline (i.e. aligned arm removes more walls, accelerating coarsening). The *sign-flip discriminator* requires aligned gap

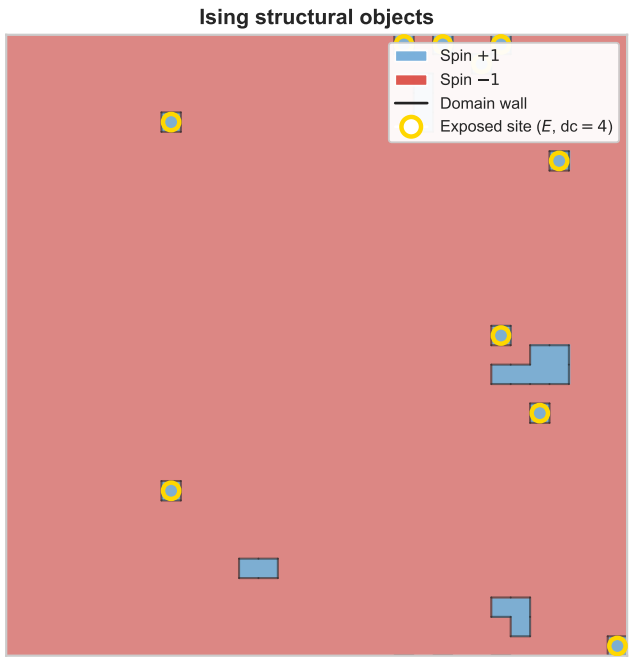

FIG. 1. **Structural objects in an ordered Ising configuration.** 32×32 patch at $T = 1.80$. Red/blue: spin $-1/+1$ domains. Black lines: domain walls. Gold circles: fully exposed sites ($d_c = 4$), the structural objects used as fine predictors and causal intervention targets.

> 0 and misaligned gap < 0, both with CIs excluding zero. Five values of ε are tested: $\varepsilon = 0$ (null control, gap should be near zero with CI spanning zero) and $\varepsilon \in \{0.02, 0.05, 0.10, 0.20\}$ (active perturbations).

IV. RESULTS

A. Structural objects and intuition

Figure 1 illustrates the key objects. Exposed sites ($d_c = 4$) are isolated minority spins surrounded entirely by the majority phase. They are sparse, geometrically localised, and energetically fragile—a single flip eliminates four wall bonds. Junction sites ($d_c = 2$, corner type) mark the bends of wall segments. Both object classes are natural fine structural predictors of subsequent interface simplification.

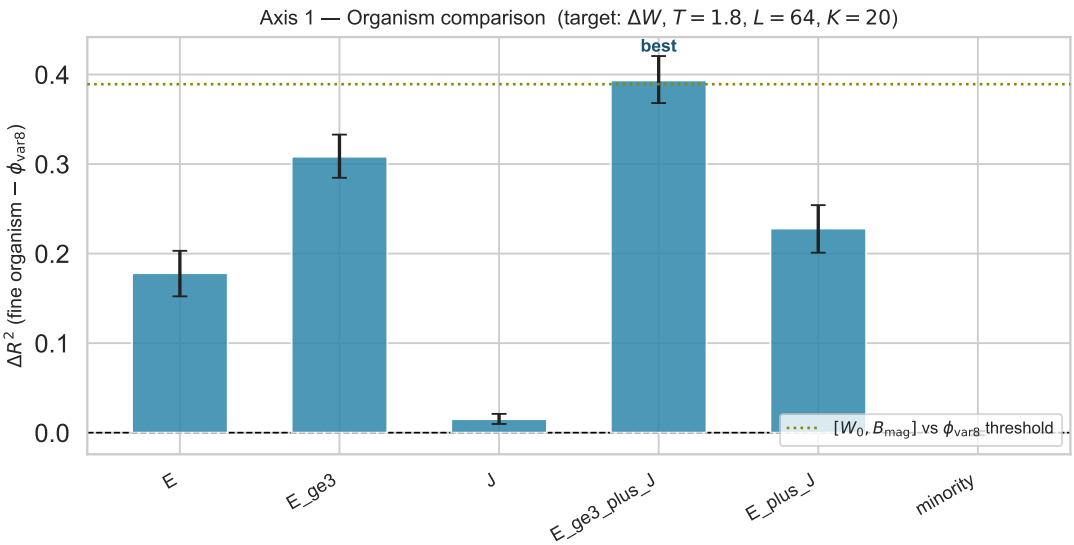

FIG. 2. **Organism comparison ($T = 1.80$, target ΔW).** $\Delta R^2 = R^2(\text{fine}) - R^2(\phi_{\text{var8}})$ with bootstrap 95% CIs. Blue: fine wins; a red bar would indicate coarse wins. $E_{\geq 3} + J$ (two-column model) achieves the largest advantage.

B. Axis 1: organism comparison

Figure 2 shows fine-over-coarse predictive advantages for all fine organisms at $T = 1.80$, target ΔW.

The best organism is $E_{\geq 3} + J$, achieving $\Delta R^2 = +0.393$ (CI $[+0.368, +0.421]$). Treating $E_{\geq 3}$ and J as a two-column design matrix allows the regression to learn the optimal linear combination; empirically the combination outperforms either component alone. The coarse rival ϕ_{var8} measures large-scale domain ordering, which changes slowly in the ordered phase; the predictive signal for interface-level change lies precisely in the fine-scale topology that the block average discards.

Note that $R^2(\phi_{\text{var8}}, \Delta W) \approx 0$ at $T = 1.80$: the block-variance rival is indistinguishable from a mean-prediction baseline for this target in the ordered phase, making the headline $\Delta R^2 = +0.393$ a comparison against a near-null baseline. Against the more informative coarse rival $[W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]$—which achieves $R^2 = 0.389$ for ΔW—the fine champion's advantage narrows to $\Delta R^2 = 0.004$ (95% CI $[-0.019, +0.027]$), a margin whose CI includes zero. The fine organism and $[W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]$ are therefore *statistically indistinguishable as predictors* of ΔW. This is not a failure of the fine description; it is the basis of the dissociation result

(Section IV F): two predictors with equivalent forecasting power differ entirely in their causal leverage. The dotted line in Fig. 2 marks the $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$ reference level.

C. Axis 2: regime crossover

TABLE I. **Regime crossover: ΔR^2 for E vs ϕ_{var8} on ΔW.** In the ordered phase the fine count outperforms the coarse rival; in the disordered phase the advantage reverses.

Regime	Temperature	ΔR^2	95% CI
Ordered	$T = 1.80$	$+0.178$	$[+0.152, +0.205]$
Disordered	$T = 2.50$	-0.071	$[-0.089, -0.052]$

Table I shows the regime comparison for E versus ϕ_{var8}. Fine wins in the ordered phase ($+0.178$); coarse wins in the disordered phase (-0.071). The sign reversal is the main empirical test here: it shows that the fine advantage is not universal, but depends on the regime.

The physical interpretation is straightforward. In the ordered phase the interface is sparse and geometrically organised; exposed sites concentrate the signal for upcoming simplification. In the disordered phase almost every site qualifies as "exposed," the concept loses discriminative power, and large-scale bulk fluctuations captured by ϕ_{var8} become the better predictor. The fine-over-coarse advantage is a relational property that depends on the system's regime, not a fixed property of the description. The crossover is not specific to E: the champion organism $E_{\geq 3} + J$ also reverses sign between regimes, confirming the crossover is a regime property, not an artefact of the specific fine predictor used for Axis A.

D. Axis 3: target specificity

A methodological note: since $E_{\geq 3} + J$ is defined from wall-boundary geometry, it is expected *a priori* that ΔW will benefit more than targets unrelated to interfaces. The contribution of Axis 3 is quantitative rather than qualitative: the fine-over-coarse ΔR^2 for ΔW is $+0.391$, while for targets driven by bulk dynamics (e.g., changed-site fraction) it is near zero. This quantifies how much of the fine description's predictive value is specifically

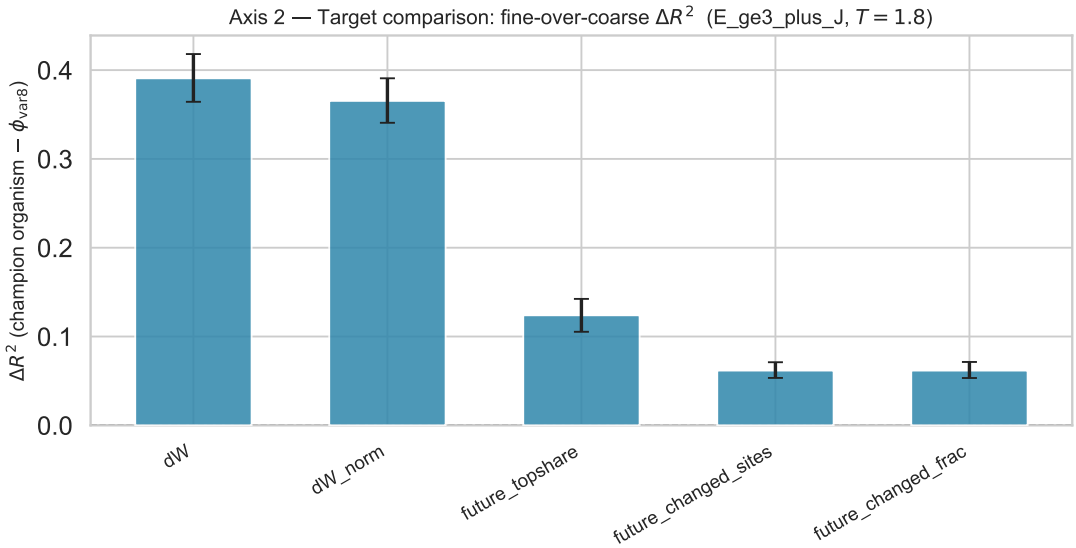

FIG. 3. **Target comparison ($T = 1.80$, predictor $E_{\geq 3} + J$).** ΔR^2 = fine − coarse across future targets. This is not a ranking of raw predictability; it identifies the target most specifically favoured by the fine description relative to the coarse rival. ΔW achieves the largest fine advantage.

interface-relevant versus generic.

Figure 3 shows which future target is most specifically favoured by $E_{\geq 3} + J$ relative to ϕ_{var8}. The criterion is ΔR^2, not raw R^2. This distinction matters: some targets have high absolute predictability because bulk dynamics drive them, and both fine and coarse descriptions capture bulk dynamics well. Measuring fine-over-coarse ΔR^2 identifies the target where the *marginal value* of fine over coarse information is largest.

The answer is ΔW: $\Delta R^2 = +0.391$, fine $R^2 = 0.393$, coarse $R^2 = 0.000$. Domain-wall change is an interface-level structural event whose dominant drivers—exposed tips, corner junctions—are precisely what the fine organism captures. The central result of this axis: **ΔW is the target most specifically favoured by fine structural descriptions in ordered Ising, under a fine-over-coarse criterion.**

E. Axis 4: direction-specific causal control

Figures 4–5 and Table II present the causal generator test. The result is EARNED: 4/4 active ε values pass the sign-flip discriminator (the $\varepsilon = 0$ null produces a gap consistent with zero as expected). The aligned arm consistently removes more walls than baseline (gap

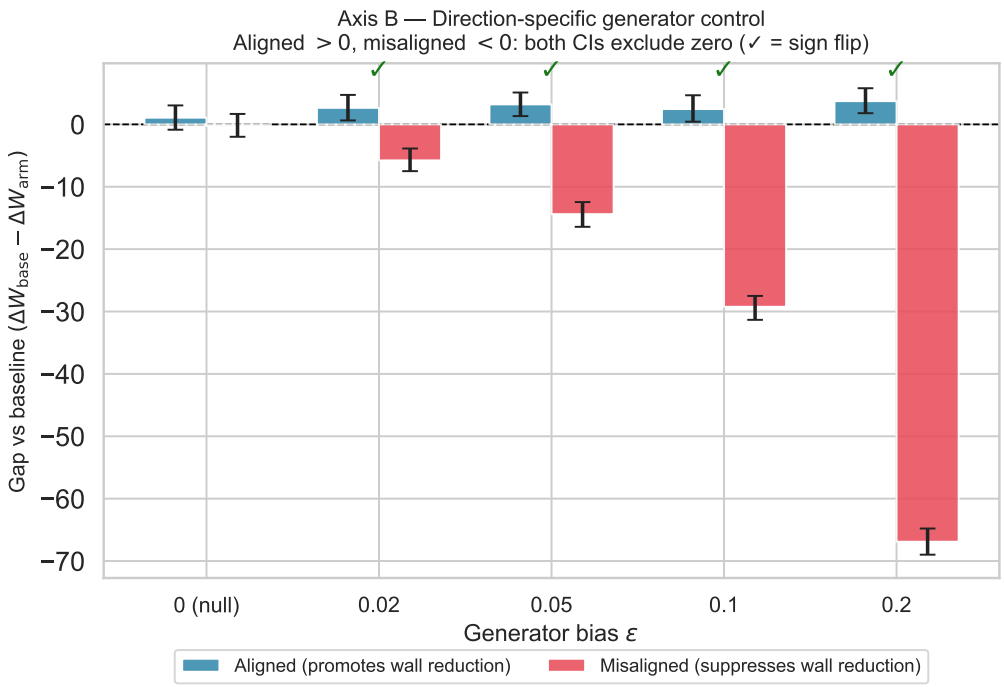

FIG. 4. **Direction-specific generator causal test.** Bars: gap (baseline − arm) on ΔW. Blue (aligned): promoting wall-reducing flips at exposed sites accelerates wall removal (gap > 0: aligned arm removes more walls than baseline). Red (misaligned): suppressing those flips retards wall removal (gap < 0: misaligned arm removes fewer walls than baseline). Four of five ε values produce a sign flip (✓): aligned CI > 0, misaligned CI < 0, both excluding zero (the $\varepsilon = 0$ null produces a gap consistent with zero as expected). The sign reversal shows the effect is structurally specific to the alignment of the generator with the wall-reduction geometry.

at $\varepsilon = 0.10$: $+2.46$, CI excludes zero); the misaligned arm consistently removes fewer (gap: -29.24, CI excludes zero).

a. Why sign flip $\neq$ generic perturbation. Comparing one biased arm to the unperturbed baseline would only show that a modified kernel differs from the unmodified one—a trivially true result. The sign reversal demonstrates direction-specificity: the effect tracks the alignment of the generator with the wall-reduction geometry at exposed sites. Promoting wall-reducing transitions at exposed sites accelerates future wall removal; suppressing them retards it. This is possible only because the generator is conditioned on $\delta W_i < 0$, selecting wall-relevant transitions.

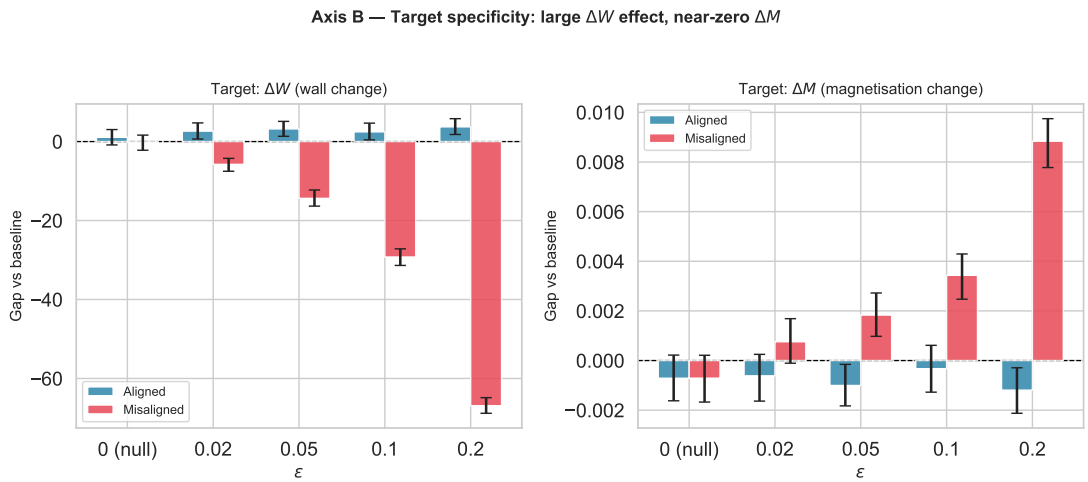

FIG. 5. **Target specificity: ΔW versus ΔM.** Left: the ΔW sign flip. Right: corresponding ΔM effect. The dominant effect is on ΔW. ΔM coupling is comparatively small at low and high ε; a modest drift appears at intermediate ε but does not approach the magnitude of the ΔW effect.

TABLE II. **Axis 4 sign-flip ladder.** Gap = baseline − arm on ΔW. Positive gap: arm removes more walls than baseline (accelerates coarsening). Negative gap: arm removes fewer walls (retards coarsening). 4/4 sign flips (excluding $\varepsilon = 0$ null).

ε	Aligned gap	Misaligned gap	Sign flip
0 (null)	≈ 0, CI spans 0	≈ 0, CI spans 0	—
0.02	> 0, CI excl. 0	< 0, CI excl. 0	✓
0.05	> 0, CI excl. 0	< 0, CI excl. 0	✓
0.10	$+2.46$, CI excl. 0	-29.24, CI excl. 0	✓
0.20	> 0, CI excl. 0	< 0, CI excl. 0	✓

b. Gap asymmetry. The aligned and misaligned gaps are not equal in magnitude: at $\varepsilon = 0.10$ the aligned gap is $+2.46$ while the misaligned gap is -29.24, a ratio of approximately $11.9\times$. This asymmetry has a structural explanation. Fully exposed sites at $T = 1.80$ flip with probability $P \approx 0.988$ under the unperturbed Glauber kernel; the aligned arm can add at most $\min(1, 0.988 + \varepsilon) - 0.988 \approx \varepsilon_{\text{eff}} \ll \varepsilon$ (ceiling effect), while the misaligned arm subtracts the full ε (no floor reached). The misaligned arm therefore perturbs the dynamics more strongly at the same nominal ε, producing a larger gap magnitude. This asymmetry is

expected and does not undermine the sign-flip discriminator; it does mean the experiment is a stronger test of suppression than of promotion at these temperatures.

c. Direction dominance. A companion probe ($N = 2000$ worlds, same L, K, T) tested whether *which sites* receive the bias matters—comparing a site-selection aligned arm against a site-selection anti-aligned arm at the same nominal ε. No CI-supported advantage for site-selection alignment was found at any $\varepsilon \in \{0.02, 0.05, 0.10, 0.20\}$; all confidence intervals straddled zero. The causal leverage therefore resides in the *direction* of flips (toward wall-reducing transitions) rather than in site identity per se. This is consistent with the ceiling effect described above: exposed sites are already at $P_{\text{flip}} \approx 0.988$, so choosing *which* exposed site to bias has negligible impact compared with choosing *whether* to increase or decrease the flip probability.

d. Target specificity. Figure 5 shows the ΔM effect. The dominant causal effect is on ΔW. ΔM coupling is comparatively small at low and high ε. We do not claim ΔM is strictly null across all ε; we claim the intervention is primarily directed at domain-wall evolution, consistent with its design.

e. Scope. Axis 4 earns: in ordered Ising at $T = 1.80$, a structure-aligned generator perturbation produces a direction-specific causal effect on future ΔW. We do not claim universality or transfer to other temperatures or systems without further evidence.

F. Predictor-handle dissociation

Two descriptions of the same configuration predict ΔW with statistically indistinguishable accuracy:

$$R^2([W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]) = 0.389, \qquad R^2(E_{\geq 3} + J) \approx 0.393, \qquad \Delta R^2 = 0.004 \ \ \text{(CI includes zero)}. \tag{8}$$

Both also outperform the single-feature count $R^2(E) = 0.181$ by a large margin (+0.208). The key asymmetry is causal, not predictive: the generator bias of Axis 4 is conditioned on the local exposed-site geometry that $E_{\geq 3} + J$ encodes, and produces a direction-specific sign flip (4/4). The aggregate $[W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]$ carries no site-specific structural information and cannot be used as a generator-level causal handle. **Two descriptions with equivalent predictive power over ΔW differ entirely in their causal leverage within the same system at the same temperature.**

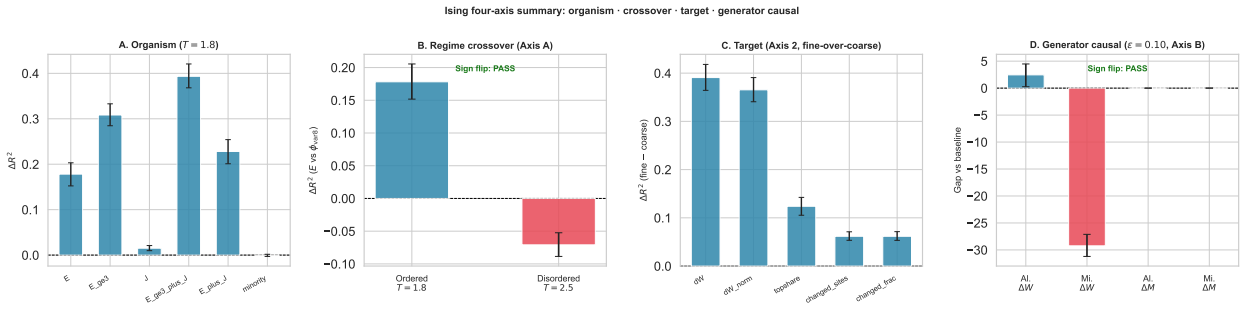

FIG. 6. **Four-component summary panel.** (**A**) Axis 1 organism comparison: $E_{\geq 3} + J$ is the champion. (**B**) Axis 2 regime crossover: fine wins ordered, coarse wins disordered. (**C**) Axis 3 target comparison: ΔW is the most fine-specific target. (**D**) Axis 4 causal test at $\varepsilon = 0.10$: aligned gap on ΔW positive, misaligned negative; ΔM comparatively small. $N = 3000$ predictive worlds, 3000 causal worlds, $L = 64$, $K = 20$.

Two caveats. First, this does not mean coarse descriptions are generally better: $[W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]$ is predictively sufficient for ΔW on a statistical forecasting task, but it does not identify the specific sites that drive coarsening. The fine structure does identify those sites, and that is precisely what enables the generator-level intervention of Axis 4. Second, the dissociation is a property of this specific predictor-target pair at this temperature; it may not hold for other pairs.

G. Synthesis

Figure 6 summarises all four components. In the ordered phase, exposed-site and junction structure carries predictive information that coarse averaging discards; this advantage is regime-specific. Under the fine-over-coarse criterion, ΔW is the most fine-specific target. The causal sign-flip confirms that the structural handle is direction-specific. And the predictor-handle dissociation shows that predictive sufficiency and causal access are different properties of a description. All four results are independently earned and jointly coherent.

V. DISCUSSION

A. What the ordered-regime fine advantage means

The fine advantage is not a trivial consequence of resolution. More bits do not automatically improve out-of-sample prediction for a specific target. What $E_{\geq 3} + J$ captures is the fragility topology of the interface: the geometrically special locations most likely to simplify in the next K steps. Coarse 8×8 block averages wash out this topology. The result is consistent with a broader principle: fine-description advantage appears when the predictive signal is concentrated in sparse, structurally special objects that coarse summaries discard—and disappears when those objects lose their sparse, special character.

B. Why the regime crossover is the main empirical test

The sign reversal between ordered and disordered phases rules out three confounds simultaneously. It rules out that fine organisms are always better because they contain more information. It rules out that the advantage is an artefact of the specific coarse rival chosen. And it provides a physical narrative tied to the phase structure: as thermal fluctuations grow near T_c, interfaces roughen, the exposed-site concept loses discriminative power [1], and bulk fluctuations become the better predictor. A finding without a crossover would be scientifically weaker.

C. Why Axis 3 requires the fine-over-coarse criterion

Measuring Axis 3 by raw R^2 would conflate fine-over-coarse advantage with raw predictability. Some targets are easy to predict in absolute terms because bulk dynamics drive them, and both fine and coarse descriptions track bulk dynamics well. The fine-over-coarse ΔR^2 criterion identifies the target where the *marginal value* of fine over coarse information is largest. That target is ΔW, consistently and for clear structural reasons. Reporting Axis 3 by raw R^2 would risk pointing to the wrong target and would weaken the structural argument.

D. Why Axis 4 is stronger than a generic gap

Any modification to the Glauber kernel differs from the unmodified kernel. What Axis 4 demonstrates is that the *direction* of the modification matters, in the way predicted by the fine structural description. The misaligned arm provides the internal negative control. Reversing the alignment reverses the causal effect. This pattern supports the interpretation that the effect is structurally specific, rather than a generic perturbation effect [10, 13].

E. The dissociation and its implications

The predictor-handle dissociation (Section IV F) reveals a sharp separation between two properties of a description: predictive accuracy and causal leverage. The aggregate coarse state $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$ and the fine champion $E_{\geq 3} + J$ achieve statistically indistinguishable out-of-sample R^2 for ΔW (gap CI includes zero). Yet only $E_{\geq 3} + J$—or more precisely, the exposed-site geometry it encodes—can be used to construct a direction-specific causal handle: the generator bias of Axis 4 acts on locally identified exposed sites, which $[W_0, B_{\mathrm{mag}}]$ does not resolve. The two descriptions encode complementary information: W_0 summarises *how much* coarsening will occur on average (aggregate potential), while exposed-site geometry identifies *where* the next coarsening events will occur (structural localisation). Equal predictive power masks a qualitative difference in causal accessibility.

A scientist selecting an intervention target based on predictive accuracy alone could not distinguish between these two descriptions—and would lose the ability to perform the direction-specific control demonstrated in Axis 4.

F. Cross-system comparison

The distinction between site-selection and flip-direction causal leverage is not universal. In a companion cellular-automaton (CA) study, site-selection *anti-alignment*—biasing transitions *away* from the structure-predicted target—produced a consistent effect across all 12 tested conditions, indicating that site identity is the operative causal handle in that system. The Ising and CA results are therefore qualitatively different: in Ising, causal power is direction-dominated because exposed sites are already near the flip-probability ceiling; in the CA, causal power is site-selection dominated because site identity determines transition eligibility in a

way that is not saturated. These two systems provide an empirical contrast suggesting that the dominant form of causal leverage—site-structural identity versus transition direction—varies with the dynamical regime and the degree to which flip probabilities are already saturated by the base dynamics.

G. Limitations and extensions

Results are scoped to ordered 2D Ising, $L = 64$, $K = 20$. Transfer to other models is not automatic. The causal result (Axis 4) is topology-sensitive: the binary-spin structure is important for a single flip to simultaneously eliminate multiple domain-wall bonds at an exposed site. Extension to Potts and Clock models would require identifying analogous geometrically special objects under multi-state spins. Extension to quantum systems (Bose-Hubbard chain) and continuous-field systems (XY, ϕ^4) requires adapting the exposed-defect concept; these are open directions.

VI. CONCLUSION

We have reported four empirical results and one dissociation result for fine and coarse descriptions of ordered Ising dynamics.

1. **Axis 1 (organism comparison):** $E_{\geq 3}+J$ achieves $\Delta R^2 = +0.393$ (CI $[+0.368, +0.421]$) for future ΔW in the ordered phase.

2. **Axis 2 (regime crossover):** The fine advantage reverses: $+0.178$ (ordered) versus -0.071 (disordered). The fine-over-coarse advantage is regime-dependent.

3. **Axis 3 (target specificity):** Under the fine-over-coarse criterion, ΔW is the most fine-specific target (fine $R^2 = 0.393$, coarse $R^2 = 0.000$, $\Delta R^2 = +0.391$).

4. **Axis 4 (direction-specific causal control):** Structure-aligned generator bias at exposed sites produces a 4/4 sign-flip on future ΔW. All CIs exclude zero.

5. **Predictor-handle dissociation:** $[W_0, B_{\text{mag}}]$ ($R^2 = 0.389$) and $E_{\geq 3} + J$ ($R^2 \approx 0.393$) are statistically indistinguishable as predictors of ΔW ($\Delta R^2 = 0.004$, 95% CI includes

zero), yet only the fine structure serves as a direction-specific causal handle. The best predictor and the best causal handle are different objects.

In this system, the relative usefulness of fine and coarse descriptions depends on the target and the regime. The Ising model provides a clean test case for these distinctions.

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DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

All simulation code, analysis scripts, and generated data are available at https://github.com/kunalb541/Ising.

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